

TV Section

Addressing the Cedar Valley's sports facility drought.

Video	Audio
Steffen Coaching	After years of spending money on gas to get to tournaments and training camps, Trace Steffen, an assistant baseball coach at Cedar Falls High School, has had enough.
Steffen talking to people at meetings	Steffen is working towards launching a sports performance facility for baseball and softball right here in Cedar Falls
Footage of a sports training camp	Coupled with a turf sports complex being discussed here in the Cedar Valley, Cedar Falls will not only be capable of hosting tournaments but also provide a space for athletes to improve their skills.
Steffen and athletes walking through a door.	"I want there to be a clear front door that wherever you want to walk in at you got a place where you can go and you can learn what you need to learn and have access to that stuff."
B-roll of baseball and softball fields in Cedar Valley from smallest to largest.	The facility is planned to be beyond just baseball and softball fields "to host really, a multitude of levels... from, the lowest, smallest kids playing T-ball all the way up to high school teams, and maybe even beyond...
B-roll of other sports happening on already existing fields or just b-roll of these other sports.	And to do that on a turf, kind of a multi-use turf facility. So it could, it could act as certainly as a baseball or softball fields, but also be able to be soccer, rugby, flag football, potentially even field hockey and lacrosse, as those sports come along down the road."
B-roll of the riverfront fields. (I believe they are labeled with what level they are for) Maybe having games currently happening on the fields.	But why put money and energy into this? "we have,, eight-year-olds up, kind of like you can kind of get by with it up until 12 years old, facilities that are okay. But then once you get

	beyond that, our facilities in the Cedar Valley are just amazingly nonexistent.”
Shots of different fields you can drive by in the Cedar Valley.	“ it's not that they there aren't some fields. You drive by them, and you look and you see fields, but they're just not suitable for anything past the littlest of little leagues.”
Athletes in travel team uniforms loading cars	When it comes to travel teams, these teams are usually too big for these fields, resulting in a lot of travel.
B-roll of the same team in like cedar rapids at a tournament.	“We literally will travel an hour and a half, two hours, sometimes three hours, and play the team that was like across the street,”
Steffen coaching again.	Another major problem Steffen has is regarding training facilities in the Cedar Valley,
Video of Steffen during the interview	“But I really think that we have a bigger issue in this community where we don't have we we've unintentionally created a gap where people don't have access to higher-level coaching because we don't have the right training facilities inside of our community.”
B-roll of the interim facility.	Steffen has secured an interim facility to use. He has also made connections with Wilson athletics and Chip's performance, who can help with getting the program center staff to coach.
Footage of a Cedar Valley team(or multiple) playing.	Steffen believes this sports performance center will help address all of these problems to provide the Cedar Valley with the level and quality of sports it is capable of.
Video of Steffen during the interview	“It's not about, you know, exclusivity, it's about inclusivity.”

Written Part

Addressing the Cedar Valley's Sports Facility Drought

By: Easton Steffen

After years of spending money on gas to get to tournaments and training camps, Trace Steffen, an assistant baseball coach at Cedar Falls High School, has seen enough. Steffen knows that the Cedar Valley would be the perfect place for a sports performance center that serves not only the Cedar Valley but also northeast Iowa in general. The goal is that the facility will not only help with hosting tournaments but also provide a space for athletes to improve their skills. "I want there to be a clear front door that wherever you want to walk in at you got a place where you can go and you can learn what you need to learn and have access to that stuff." Steffen said regarding his ultimate goal for the center.

The facility is planned to be beyond just baseball and softball fields. Steffen wants the center to "host really, a multitude of levels of [sports] from... the lowest, smallest kids playing T-ball all the way up to high school teams, and maybe even beyond. And to do that on a turf, kind of a multi-use turf facility. So it could, it could act as certainly as a baseball or softball fields, but also be able to be soccer, rugby, flag football, potentially even field hockey and lacrosse, as those sports come along down the road." Having a space where these other sports can take place allows for the center to be as diverse as possible and serve a wider variety of people in the community.

The reason for this project despite having several fields in the Cedar Valley is due to the condition and usecases for the fields. "So we have, like, eight-year-olds up, kind of like you can kind of get by with it up until 12 years old, facilities that are okay. But then once you get beyond that, our facilities in the Cedar Valley are just amazingly nonexistent." The facilities in the Cedar Valley are "not suitable for anything past the littlest of little leagues." Steffen also points out that any fields that could be used for higher-levels are either locked behind school district rules or in such poor condition that it's unusable. The only field you can rent is owned by UNI and is not maintained. It doesn't even have a mound to pitch from.

Another benefit to having the sports performance center is that they could host tournaments for travel baseball and softball teams. The fields already present are too small for most travel teams. This means that teams have to travel to attend tournaments on correctly sized fields. "We literally will travel an hour and a half, two hours, sometimes three hours, and play the team that was like across the street," Having fields for higher-level teams saves the team and parents of athletes hundreds of dollars on gas.

But this project is more than just a way to bring in money by hosting tournaments or training camps. "Why do we do sports? And it's not to fund our hotels. Sports are like a character and like a physical development tool. It's about like giving these kids an opportunity to sometimes struggle, to develop, to have fun, to physically develop, but also to to develop that kind of resilience that Sports teaches, so that when something goes wrong, that they, you know, hopefully, can work through those things." Having access to sports gives athletes a space to grow without worry.

Another major problem Steffen has is regarding the lack of training facilities in the Cedar Valley, "But I really think that we have a bigger issue in this community where we don't have we

we've unintentionally created a gap where people don't have access to higher-level coaching because we don't have the right training facilities inside of our community." Without these spaces it vastly limits the number and variety of people who participate in sports.

"We actually have an interim facility that we can move into as early as, like, in the next like 60 days, where we could set up nine batting cages and have a sports performance facility." Steffen shared. He has also made connections with Wilson athletics and Chip's performance, who can help with getting the program center staff to coach. There are many talks going on currently to make this performance center a reality. This sports performance center will help address all of these problems to provide the Cedar Valley with the level and quality of sports it is capable of. As Steffen stated, "It's not about, you know, exclusivity, it's about inclusivity."